Symposium – May 1st and 2nd 2026

The Human Outside of Language: Precarious Lives, New Clinics

The University at Buffalo Clinical and Translational Research Center (CTRC), room 5019
875 Ellicott St, Buffalo, NY 14203. Free and open to the public.

Friday, May 1st

9:30 – Coffee

10:00 – Introductory Remarks – Fernanda Negrete

10:30 – Private Clinics in North America

Bret Fimiani, *The Fall of Delusion and the Emergence of the Subject: The Psychotic's Creation of a Space within Society*

Daniel Wilson, *Making a Space for Subjective Consciousness through Creative Play with Autistic Children*

Heidi Arsenault, *Space and time for children who did not enter into language*

12:30 – Lunch Break

2:15 – Public Clinical Projects in North America

Aileen Schloerb, *What's at Stake for a Child in the Condition of Being Human?*

Alexander Miller, *The Centre for the Psychoanalytic Treatment of Psychosis ("the 388") in Quebec City*

4:15 – Coffee

4:30 – Keynote Address

Derek Humphreys, *The space, the living, the human: A Metapsychology of the Social Bond in the Clinics of Exclusion*

Saturday, May 2nd

9:45 - Coffee

10:00 - Keynote Address

Catherine Perret, *The Common by Fernand Deligny*

12:00 – Lunch Provided at CTRC 5th floor

1:30 – CSPC Visiting Scholar Presentation – Psychosocial Fieldwork in Iraq

Ali İhsan Yaka, *Conceptualizing Êzidî Femicide as Communicide: Psychoanalytic Reflections on the Paranoiac Dimension of Language in Genocide*

2:30 – Coffee

2:45 – On the Aesthetic – Transcultural SPIIRAL Working Group

Marta Aleksandrowicz, John Anspach, Romain Pasquer, Melissa Wright,
Fathers and Sons in Adolescence: Femicide and the Impasse of Puberty

4:45 – Concluding Discussion with all presenters, moderators, audience

6:15 – Reception at Big Ditch Brewery (Sponsored by the Melodia E. Jones Fund)

Description

The Human Outside of Language: Precarious Lives, New Clinics

The Center's 2026 symposium considers the ongoing relevance of Fernand Deligny and GIFRIC (Groupe Interdisciplinaire Freudien de Recherches et Interventions Cliniques, the Freudian Interdisciplinary Group for Research and Clinical and Cultural Interventions), as two original visions that emerged in different world regions to sustain the life and experience of young people in precarious and extreme conditions, deemed by society as "untreatable."

From the 1940s until his death in 1996, Fernand Deligny developed clinical projects in rural France with and for children and adolescents labeled "ineducable," "incurable," agitated and autistic. In 1977, Willy Apollon founded GIFRIC in Quebec, and as one of its projects, "the 388," the Center for Psychoanalytic Treatment of Psychotic Young Adults, which welcomed users between 1982 and 2025 in downtown Quebec City. Both Deligny's and GIFRIC's initiatives considered unconscious desires and the discontents of civilization, and both looked beyond neurotic normativity and toward aesthetic experimentation to orient their offer of a space for what remains out of language. This symposium brings together current research and clinical work inspired and informed by these two figures, for whom the Lacanian notion of "not giving up on one's desire" involved pushing cultural and civilizational limits, including those of psychoanalysis, and rethinking the offer of a space where language fails. It principally focuses on projects with young people in France and North America, who are non-speaking, psychotic, or in precarious or violent situations, where aesthetics and its sense of the human address outside of language and the cultural Other are in play.

Apollon underscores the age of *mondialisation*, the constant clash of cultures and civilizations in which we live and face the challenge of offering a space and a future for the human after the loss of the believable, which civilizations sustained. What does it mean to attend to young people who in today's circumstances either refuse to enter collective consciousness or are victims of discourses formatting sexuality, imprisoning them in misogyny and escalating femicide?

Two keynote addresses will be offered by Derek Humphreys and Catherine Perret. Panels, clinical and critical, bring together Marta Aleksandrowicz, John Anspach, Heidi Arsenault, Bret Fimiani, Alexander

Miller, Romain Pasquer, Aileen Schloerb, Daniel Wilson, and Melissa Wright. The symposium welcomes a presentation by the Center's current Visiting Scholar, Ali Ihsan Yaka, whose dissertation explored the application of Lacanian principles in supervision of psychosocial intervention practices after the Êzidî genocide, where gender and sexual violence were major factors.

Presentation Abstracts

The Space, the Living, the Human. A Metapsychology of the Social Bond in the Clinics of Exclusion
Derek Humphreys (Université Paris Cité)

Providing a historical perspective, Foucault has enabled us to see madness as a kind of paradigm for processes of exclusion. These processes are already present in Freudian theory as part of the construction of the *ego* (*Das Unheimliche*) and of culture (*Der Mann Moses und die monotheistische Religion).* Lacan, for his part, has critically examined the position of the *ego* in culture, and particularly within the field of psychoanalysis. Deleuze has sought to take this reflection further, acknowledging the richness of the Freudian thermodynamic apparatus whilst lamenting its reduction to the myth and tragedy of Oedipus. It is on this basis that the exclusion at work in madness and autism has led to a new clinical approach through the creation of novel forms of bonding within the context of institutional psychotherapy (Oury) and schizoanalysis (Guattari). Even more radical has been Deligny's attempt to create a network of spaces for living and of neighboring presences in the Cévennes.

In this presentation, I shall attempt to explain how these experiences enable us to reflect on other common experiences of exclusion, particularly those in which we recognise suffering caused by a sense of alienation from culture and social systems of exchange, as is the case with extreme precariousness, especially when this is linked to a migrant experience. This exploration of the 'clinic of exclusion' will lead me to address the difficulties of encountering otherness and the need for the one who 'welcomes' to abandon customary cultural and social references in order to access new ways of bonding, of creating the common and the collective. In order to do so, we will address three central aspects of this process: attention to the sensible (voice, body, space), the possibility of cartographing these sensible elements in the creation of a perceived psychic space, and the narrativity required for the reallocation of each person's position within this new collective space. This work, in its approach to psychoanalysis, will allow us to examine the function of the psychic apparatus in relation to the construction of the social bond, and also to explore the foundations of this work in what we usually call counter-transference. Finally, I shall attempt to link these experiences to other situations that also allow us to reflect on contemporary manifestations of exclusion, primarily physical disabilities and the experiences of those living with a severely damaged body or who are dependent on machines to survive.

About the Common by Fernand Deligny
Catherine Perret (Professor Emerita Université Paris 8)

This paper uses the path of theory and description to propose a historical and anthropological approach to the practice and the meaning of "the common" Fernand Deligny experimented with from 1967 until his death in 1996: first as he worked as a specialized educator with children and teenagers with disabilities, and then, when he withdrew from institutional contexts and went to the Cévennes, with his network, with the project to live in "close presence" of nonverbal children suffering from severe autism.

The paper follows a twofold purpose: on the one hand, it analyzes the practices developed by Deligny and his network in response to the crisis of Western civilization of the 20th century and to the "silencing" that

dominated the history of (child) psychiatry during the same period; on the other hand, it shows how these practices, writing, films, maps, allowed Deligny and his team to uncover a common agency which "outside of language" defines humanity as living species.

The Fall of Delusion and the Emergence of the Subject: the Psychotic's Creation of a Space within Society
Bret Fimiani (Psychoanalyst in Private Practice, Oakland, CA)

I will discuss clinical concepts central to my work with psychosis, including the 'ethics' of the analyst and the analysand, and the consequences of the psychotic's entry into 'transference'--defined here as a 'desire to know' about one's own psychosis. Drawing on clinical material, I propose a framework for understanding how subjects experiencing psychosis can emerge from its destructive dimensions and engage with the world in new and, sometimes, creative ways.

Bret Fimiani is a psychoanalyst of the Lacanian School of Psychoanalysis and a member of SPIIRAL. He works with people experiencing psychosis and extreme states in his private practice in Oakland, CA and he is on the board of directors for the Bay Area Hearing Voices Network. His recent book on psychosis is titled *Psychosis and Extreme States: An Ethic for Treatment* (Palgrave-Macmillan 2021).

Making a Space for Subjective Consciousness through Creative Play with Autistic Children
Daniel Wilson (Aria Music Therapy, Montreal)

At 3 or 4 years of age, all children experience an unbridgeable gap between their subjective consciousness and the reality that is structured on the basis of the Other's observation. Children who we call autistic do not identify with what the Other observes, and do not enter into the space and time of the Other's observation. Our work with autistic children thus requires us to distinguish between collective consciousness (what B.F. Skinner calls the consciousness produced by the "verbal community") and the manifestations of an inaccessible subjective consciousness, where the child is exploring a universe of singular representations.

Daniel Wilson has a PhD in English Literature, and has published articles on various topics in psychoanalysis. He is a member of GIFRIC, the École Freudienne de Quebec, and SPIIRAL. With Heidi Arsenault, Daniel works with autistic children in the context of a music therapy practice.

Space and Time for Children Who Did Not Enter into Language
Heidi Arsenault (Aria Music Therapy, Montreal)

Language functions as a filtering system that represses the singularity of perceptions and representations. Working with autistic children involves entering into the space-time constructed by the child, rather than working to bring the child into the space-time of the collective. In this presentation I'll talk about different youtube videos that autistic children have shared with me, and made, which bring out this difference.

Heidi Arsenault is a board-certified music therapist based in Montreal. Her current projects include Aria, a music therapy practice for autistic children, with Daniel Wilson. She is a member of GIFRIC, of SPIIRAL, and of the École Freudienne du Québec.

What's at Stake for A Child in The Condition of Being Human?

Aileen Schloerb (Chicago Inner City Public Schools)

This presentation will examine how a child moving into puberty encounters this problematic at the level of lived experience within the context of the social institutions of the family and the school. So as to offer young people the possibility of a space to manage the effects of their experiences which these social institutions both contribute to and are unable to manage, we've created a project within the context of inner city public schools through which to accompany children individually or through small groups in their work of growing up. The metapsychology developed by Willy Apollon and the work of GIFRIC has been invaluable in orienting our practice and in conceptualizing what unfolds.

Aileen Schloerb PhD has developed and worked with a project in inner city public schools since 2008 serving at various times as director, clinician, and supervisor of this intervention mandated to work with children, parents, teachers and communities exposed to structural violence in urban neighborhoods. A member of GIFRIC, she is interested in bringing its metapsychological orientation to bear on collaborations with marginalized communities.

The Centre for the Psychoanalytic Treatment of Psychosis ("the 388") in Quebec City
Alexander Miller (University of Essex)

This paper focuses on the Centre for the Psychoanalytic Treatment of Psychosis ("the 388") in Quebec City. Taking its recent closure as a point of departure, I argue that what was at stake cannot be reduced to a dispute over evaluative standards or even to competing theories of psychosis and its treatment, but must be understood in relation to incommensurable practical worlds. Drawing on practice-based approaches, I shift attention to the conditions under which psychosis is engaged in practice, examining how threshold arrangements at the 388 gave rise to a clinical world in which psychosis could become otherwise.

Alexander Miller is a Marie Sklodowska Curie Postdoctoral Fellow in the Department of Psychosocial and Psychoanalytic Studies at the University of Essex (UK). He has a doctorate in Psychology from Ghent University (Belgium) and in Comparative Literature from New York University.

Conceptualizing Êzidî Femicide as Communicide: Psychoanalytic Reflections on the Paranoiac Dimension of Language in Genocide
Ali İhsan Yaka (Visiting Scholar, Center for the Study of Psychoanalysis & Culture, Buffalo)

This research project combines psychosocial fieldwork in Iraq with a longitudinal, Lacanian psychoanalytic intervention, examines the 2014 Êzidî (Yazidi) genocide in relation to feminicide and communicide, and explores how language structures discourses of masculinity, gender, sexuality, and trauma in genocide contexts and psychosocial practice.

Ali İhsan Yaka, Ph.D., is a Visiting Scholar at the Center for the Study of Psychoanalysis and Culture, University at Buffalo (SUNY). He received his Ph.D. in Clinical Psychology from Middle East Technical University (METU), Turkey, in 2024. His dissertation developed a Lacanian psychoanalytic framework for examining social trauma in clinical supervision, based on remote psychosocial fieldwork conducted in Iraq during the global COVID-19 lockdown.

Fathers and Sons in Adolescence*: Femicide and the Impasse of Puberty*

Marta Aleksandrowicz (ICI Berlin), John Anspach (Cornell University), Romain Pasquer Brochard (Oberlin College), Melissa Wright (Barnard College)

This presentation expands on a year-long discussion of the recent British TV show *Adolescence* by the members of a SPIIRAL working group on the aesthetic. Centered on the act of femicide around which the show revolves, this presentation brings Willy Apollon's metapsychology–including his conceptions of the feminine, masculine, *mondialisation*, and the cultural montage of the sexual–to bear on the challenges of puberty and the possibility of adolescence. It focuses specifically on the relationships between fathers and sons and the impasses opened in the wake of the loss of the believable and its reverberations in the manosphere. At stake throughout is the question of how what remains unaddressable in the subject may be driven toward violence or, alternatively, find form in an aesthetic act, opening another space for adolescent experience beyond the sexual and its misogynistic forms.

Marta Aleksandrowicz is in psychoanalytic formation at the Lacan School of Psychoanalysis (LSP). She is also a researcher in the fields of psychoanalysis, comparative literature, and decolonial and feminist theory. She is currently an affiliated postdoctoral fellow at the ICI Berlin. She received her PhD in Comparative Literature from University at Buffalo in 2022.

John Anspach is a PhD candidate in English Literature at Cornell University. He works on modernism, psychoanalysis, and queer theory and is currently completing a dissertation on the universality and singularity of loss in early 20th c. fiction.

Romain Pasquer Brochard is an Assistant Professor of French at Oberlin College. His research and current monograph project explore the role that literary writers and their texts play in testifying to the trauma of slavery and colonialism in the French Caribbean. He obtained his PhD at Cornell University in 2022.

Melissa Wright is in psychoanalytic formation at Pulsion: The International Institute of Psychoanalysis and Psychoanalytic Psychosomatics in New York City. She is also Executive Director of the Center for Engaged Pedagogy at Barnard College. She received her PhD in Comparative Literature from University at Buffalo in 2020.

John, Marta, Melissa and Romain are collaborators of the New York Circle of the Freudian School of Quebec (EFQ), and they work together in the SPIIRAL working group on 'the aesthetic.'